to escape into the Gilgit region and Ladakh. The two most notable of these warlords were one Mahmud and one Ma Hu-Shan. The British defence forces were now worried—if military refugees could reach Leh via Aksai Chin, up the Karakash River from Khotan, would India not be under serious threat if more such warlords were able to enter Sinkiang?

This question remained unanswered and India paid a heavy price for this ambivalence 24 years later, in 1962. By 1943, during WWII, the British decided to station agents in Central Asia, who would continue to provide them with intelligence from the ground. The latter part of this chapter and the other succeeding chapters will reveal the policies that the British adapted in order to remain a dominant player in the region.

Turmoil in the Valley

Meanwhile, within the valley, political unrest had increased after the declaration of the Pakistan Resolution in Lahore, in 1941. The Lahore Resolution, presented by A. K. Fazlul Huq at the three-day general session of the All India Muslim League in Lahore on 22–24 March 1941, is popularly known as the Pakistan Resolution because it called for independent states based on religion. The Anglo-Soviet Pact made during WWII, and Stalin's subsequent disbandment of the Comintern had provided the Government of India some respite from the perceived Soviet threat to the state. Hari Singh, anticipating the inevitable departure of the British from the subcontinent, needed to broaden his popular support. He sought to do this by appointing one Muslim and one Hindu member from the legislative assembly as ministers in his government. That he even considered doing this, is a reflection of how fast socio-religious equations were changing in the state and how inadequate the state forces were of quelling any Muslim uprisings. Hari Singh chose Mirza Afzal Beg, the deputy leader of the National Conference and a close associate of Abdullah, as the Minister of Public Works and Municipalities. Wazir Ganga Ram was the Hindu minister chosen by the Maharaja.[20] Beg's collaboration with the Maharaja undoubtedly reflected Abdullah's political craftiness and his